Coaching Conversation

A simple structure for one-to-one coaching: agree the goal, explore reality and options, and commit to action.

Facilitate · GROW Model (Sir John Whitmore) · Ask More Than Tell · One-to-One Coaching

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

COACHEE: Alex (coach: Tom)

DATE: 13 May

1 Contract

AGREE THIS FIRST

What do you want from this conversation? a way to raise test risks earlier, without slowing the team

☑ Confidentiality agreed

Time: 45 minutes

2 Goal

WHAT DO YOU WANT?

QUESTIONS TO TRY

What would you like to achieve?
What would success look like?
Why does this matter to you now?
How will you know you've got there?

NOTES

Alex: "I find the risky cases when it's too late to change the design."
Success: test risks raised at refinement, not in testing.
Matters now: two bugs in Sprint 18 were found late.

3 Reality

WHERE ARE YOU NOW?

QUESTIONS TO TRY

What's happening at the moment?
What have you tried so far?
What's getting in the way?
What's within your control?

NOTES

Usually tests after the build.
Hasn't spoken up in refinement: "feels like slowing people down".
Tried: a test checklist; nobody reads it.
In control: own prep, and asking questions.

4 Options

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

QUESTIONS TO TRY

What could you do?
What else? And what else?
What would you advise a friend?
What if there were no limits?

NOTES

Ask one "what if...?" at each refinement
Pair with Priya on Example Mapping
Write test ideas on the card
Run a 15-minute risk storm
Ask Tom to prompt for risks

5 Will

WHAT WILL YOU DO?

QUESTIONS TO TRY

Which option will you take?
What's the first step, and when?
What might stop you?
How committed are you, 1–10?

NOTES

Ask a "what if...?" question at each refinement, and pair with Priya on Example Mapping for the top item.
First step: Tuesday's refinement.
Might stop me: running out of time. Commitment: 8 of 10.

6 Commitments

IN THE COACHEE'S WORDS

ACTION	BY WHEN	SUPPORT NEEDED
Ask one "what if...?" question at each refinement	from Tuesday	Tom to leave room for it
Example Mapping with Priya for the top item	next refinement	Priya's time, 25 minutes
Share what changed at the retro	end of Sprint 19	none

7 Coach's Reflection

AFTERWARDS

What I noticed: energy rose when we talked about pairing

Did I ask more than tell? mostly; I suggested one option

Follow up on: the retro after Sprint 19

"What do you want to be different by the end of this conversation?"

"What's the smallest step you could take this week?"

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